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Credit - Drishti Ias

Sustainable Tourism Push in Budget 2026-27

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For Prelims: Union Budget 2026-27 , **Buddhist Circuit** , **Swadesh Darshan Scheme** , **Eastern Ghats** , **Western Ghats** , **Turtle trails** , **Pulicat Lake** , **Global Big Cat Summit** , **Lothal , Dholavira , Swadesh Darshan 2.0** , **PRASHAD** , **AYUSH** , **UDAN Scheme** , **Dekho Apna Desh** .

For Mains: New initiatives announced for tourism development in Union Budget 2026-27, Challenges associated with tourism development in India and way forward.

Source: PIB

Why in News?

Tourism has emerged as a focal point in the **Union Budget 2026-27** , with the **government** unveiling a comprehensive set of measures aimed at positioning the **sector** as a strategic growth driver for the **Indian economy** .

- The tourism sector accounts for **5.22% of India's GDP** (total impact) with a direct share of **2.72%** , while supporting an impressive **13.34% of total employment** , according to the **India Tourism Data Compendium 2025** by the **Ministry of Tourism** .

Summary

- **Budget 2026-27** boosts tourism with **Buddhist circuits, eco-trails, Global Big Cat Summit, National Institute of Hospitality** , guide upskilling, heritage sites, medical hubs, and Purvodaya development.
- The sector faces **infrastructure gaps, overcrowding** (e.g., 1.1 crore tourists in Goa), **safety, hygiene,** visa issues, and **low foreign arrivals** (1 crore vs Thailand's 3.5 crore).
- Focus on **infrastructure (UDAN), Incredible India 2.0** , tourism-ready certification, agri-tourism, community participation, and green certification.

What New Initiatives have been Announced for Tourism Development in Union Budget 2026-27?

- **Development of Buddhist Circuits in Northeast Region** : A dedicated scheme was announced to

develop **Buddhist circuits** across Northeast India (Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Sikkim, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura), including pilgrimage interpretation centres, improved connectivity, **pilgrim amenities** , and **heritage infrastructure** .

  - This initiative builds on the experience of the **Swadesh Darshan Scheme** (launched 2014-15), under which 76 projects were sanctioned and 75 completed.

- **Eco-Trails and Sustainable Tourism Initiatives** : The Budget has proposed the development of ecologically sustainable **mountain and nature trails** in Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Jammu & Kashmir, **Araku Valley** in the **Eastern Ghats** , and **Podhigai Malai** in the **Western Ghats** .
  - **Turtle trails** along key nesting sites in the coastal areas of **Odisha, Karnataka** and **Kerala** , and **bird-watching trails** along **Pulicat Lake** in **Andhra Pradesh** have also been announced.
- **Global Big Cat Summit 2026** : India will host the **first-ever Global Big Cat Summit** in 2026, inviting heads and ministers from **95 range countries** to deliberate on **conservation, habitat protection** , scientific collaboration, and sustainable wildlife tourism.
  - This initiative reflects the **Government's intent** to elevate India's role in **eco-tourism** and **international wildlife cooperation** . India is home to **f** ive of the world's seven big cat species, i.e., **tiger, lion, leopard, snow leopard and cheetah** .
- **National Institute of Hospitality** : The **National Council for Hotel Management and Catering Technology** , Noida (Uttar Pradesh), will be upgraded to a **National Institute of Hospitality** , aimed at providing high-quality **professional education** . It will also function as a bridge between **academia, industry** and the **Government** , addressing **skill gaps** and aligning **academic training** with industry requirements.
- **Tourist Guide Upskilling Programme** : A pilot scheme for upskilling **10,000 tourist guides** across **20 iconic destinations** has been announced. It will follow a **12-week hybrid training model** combining classroom instruction, field training, and digital modules.
- **National Destination Digital Knowledge Grid** : A digital platform will be created to document **cultural, spiritual, and heritage sites** across **India** , providing resources for researchers, content creators, historians, and **tourism stakeholders** .
- **Experiential Cultural Destinations** : The Budget proposed development of **15 archaeological sites** into vibrant experiential cultural destinations, including **Lothal , Dholavira ,** Rakhigarhi, Sarnath, Hastinapur, and Leh Palace. It will complement existing schemes like **Swadesh Darshan 2.0** and **PRASHAD** .
- **Regional Medical Hubs** : A Scheme to Support States in establishing **five Regional Medical Hubs** has been introduced, aimed at promoting **India** as a global destination for **medical and wellness tourism** . The hubs will integrate advanced healthcare services, **AYUSH centres** , and medical value tourism facilitation centres.
- **Tourism Development in Purvodaya States** : The Budget proposes the creation of five tourism destinations, one in each Purvodaya state— **Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh** —under an integrated framework including the **East Coast Industrial Corridor** with a node at Durgapur (West Bengal).
  - Additionally, provisions for **4,000 electric buses** were announced to support improved connectivity, **cleaner transport** , and greater accessibility across these regions.

Initiatives Related to Tourism in India

- **Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat**
- **Dekho Apna Desh Initiative**
- **Paryatan Parv**
- **PRASAD Scheme**
- **Swadesh Darshan Scheme**

What Challenges are Associated with Tourism Development in India?

- **Inadequate Infrastructure** : Deficient transportation networks and **poor last-mile connectivity** persist as major barriers. In **2025** , **Vyas Valley (Uttarakhand)** saw **tourist footfall** surge from **200 to 30,000** over a decade, but local **infrastructure** failed to keep pace, causing capacity strains and **degraded visitor experiences** .
- **Environmental Degradation** : **Overcrowding** in fragile regions leads to **pollution, waste accumulation,** and **biodiversity loss** .
  - From **68.9 lakh** domestic tourists in **2017** , Goa's total arrivals surged to nearly **1.1 crore by 2025** , leading to congested roads, garbage heaps, beach erosion, and calls for **carrying capacity limits** .
  - The **2025** **Char Dham Yatra** attracted over **four million pilgrims** , exacerbating environmental pressures in hill stations.
- **Safety and Security Concerns** : Persistent **safety issues** , particularly for **women and solo travellers** , continue to deter visitors. **Travel advisories** from the **US and UK** have been issued, while incidents involving **foreign tourists** reinforce **negative perceptions** , pushing travellers toward Southeast Asian competitors.

- **Hygiene and Service Quality** : Inconsistent **sanitation standards** undermine **visitor satisfaction** , with **international travellers** often confining themselves to **luxury accommodations** , limiting economic benefits to local communities.
- **Visa and Regulatory Complexities** : Despite e-visa expansion, **processing delays** persist. **Overseas promotion funding** was slashed from **Rs 33 crore to Rs 3.07 crore** in **Budget 2025-26** , hampering efforts to compete with visa-on-arrival destinations like **Thailand and Vietnam** .
- **Global Competitiveness Gap** : **India** attracted only **10 million foreign tourists** in **2024** , versus **Thailand's 35 million, Malaysia's 25 million, and Vietnam's 17 million** . In 2023, Indians spent an estimated **USD 33 billion** on **overseas holidays** , citing better **value, services, and transparency** abroad.

What Steps are Needed to Promote Tourism Development in India?

- **Enhance Infrastructure and Connectivity** : Prioritize investment in **transportation networks** including **high-speed rail** , **multimodal corridors** , and regional airports under **UDAN scheme** to ensure equitable dispersal of tourism beyond major metros.
- **Revamped "Incredible India 2.0" Campaign** : Move beyond generic promotion with data-driven, **hyper-personalized** global marketing targeting specific demographics like **millennials, luxury travelers** , and **adventure enthusiasts** .
  - Expand domestic promotion via **Dekho Apna Desh** to encourage exploration of **lesser-known sites.**
- **Establish "Tourism-Ready" Certification for Destinations** : Develop **mandatory accreditation program** for tourist destinations based on benchmarks for **cleanliness, safety, accessibility, and sustainability** , creating healthy competition among states to improve standards.
- **Integrate Tourism with Rural Development** : Promote **agri-tourism** and **rural tourism** by connecting working farms and rural communities with **urban and international tourists** , providing **authentic cultural experiences** and generating additional income for farmers.
  - Integrate **local communities** under programmes like **Paryatan Mitra/Paryatan Didi** , ensuring equitable benefits reach **rural, tribal, and underserved regions** .
- **Incentivize Green Certification for the Hospitality Industry** : Launch national program to encourage **hotels, resorts, and homestays** adopting sustainable practices like **water conservation** , **waste reduction** , and **renewable energy use** . Provide marketing support to **"Green Key" certified properties** to attract environmentally conscious travelers.

Conclusion

The **Union Budget 2026-27** presents a **transformative vision** for Indian tourism through targeted initiatives like **Buddhist circuits, eco-trails, Global Big Cat Summit** , and **hospitality upgrades** . However, addressing **infrastructure gaps, environmental concerns, and global competitiveness challenges** through sustainable practices and community participation will determine the sector's success in becoming a true economic growth driver.

Drishti Mains Question

Q. Examine the major challenges confronting the Indian tourism sector. Suggest a comprehensive framework for sustainable tourism development in India

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the economic contribution of tourism to India's economy?

Tourism contributes 5.22% to GDP (total impact) and supports 13.34% of total employment, as per India Tourism Data Compendium 2025.

2. Which archaeological sites are being developed as experiential cultural destinations?

The Budget proposed development of 15 archaeological sites including Lothal, Dholavira, Rakhigarhi, Sarnath, and Hastinapur with curated walkways, interpretation centres, and heritage infrastructure.

3. What is the National Destination Digital Knowledge Grid?

It is a digital platform to document cultural, spiritual, and heritage sites across India, providing resources for researchers, content creators, and tourism stakeholders to support data-driven decision-making.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/n1mYbXM5Urg**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Mains

Q.1 How can the mountain ecosystem be restored from the negative impact of development initiatives and tourism? (2019)

Q.2 The states of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand are reaching the limits of their ecological carrying capacity due to tourism. Critically evaluate. (2015)

State of India's Environment 2026

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Source: DTE

Why in News?

The **State of India's Environment (SOE) 2026** report, released by the **Centre for Science and Environment (CSE)** and Down To Earth, warns that multiple **planetary boundaries** are being breached due to human activities, while ecological degradation is intensifying **human–tiger**

conflicts across India.

What are the Key Highlights of the State of India's Environment (SOE) 2026 Report?

- **Planetary Boundaries Crisis:** The SOE 2026 report warns that **7 of the nine planetary boundaries** have been breached, with **ocean acidification** emerging as the seventh.
  - Breached boundaries include **Climate change, Biosphere integrity, Land system change, Freshwater depletion, Biogeochemical flows, Novel entities, and Ocean acidification.**
  - Ocean acidification emerging as the seventh, ocean acidity has increased by **30–40% since the industrial era** , threatening marine ecosystems.
- **Climate Crisis Escalation: The report highlights that the world is close to breaching the** 1.5°C global warming threshold , **signalling irreversible climate impacts.**
  - Climate disruptions are arriving earlier than predicted, pushing ecosystems like coral reefs and the Amazon rainforest toward critical tipping points.
- **Biodiversity & Forest Decline:** Global forest cover has fallen to **59%** , far below the 75% safe threshold , while species extinction rates exceed **100 per million species years** (ten times the safe limit).
  - Habitat degradation and ecosystem imbalance are accelerating biodiversity loss.
- **Freshwater & Pollution Threats:** Freshwater reserves are under severe stress due to overuse and climate change.
  - The proliferation of **plastics, synthetic chemicals, and other novel entities** poses long-term ecological and health risks, highlighting the growing challenge of pollution.
- **Rising Human–Tiger Conflict:** The report notes that habitat loss, prey depletion, and increasing human proximity to forests are altering tiger behaviour and increasing encounters.
  - The invasive plant Lantana camara now occupies nearly **50% of forest and scrublands , suppressing** native grasses and reducing prey for tigers. This forces tigers to prey on cattle, increasing human–tiger interactions and conflict.

Recommendations

- **Institutional Integrity:** Strengthening the **National Green Tribunal (NGT)** and environmental clearing houses to prioritize ecological substance over procedural paperwork.
- **Sovereign Climate Action:** Integrating planetary boundaries into national accounting and shifting toward a technology-led, full-stack decarbonization.
- **Coexistence Models:** Moving toward landscape-scale governance that treats local communities as primary stakeholders in conservation rather than obstacles.

Planetary Boundaries

- **About:** The **Planetary Boundaries framework** defines the safe limits within which humanity can operate without destabilising Earth's life-support systems.
  - First proposed in **2009** by scientists led by **Johan Rockström** and updated in **2023** , it identifies **nine critical Earth system processes** that regulate planetary stability.
  - Crossing these limits increases the risk of abrupt, irreversible environmental changes that threaten ecosystems, economies, and human survival.
  - These boundaries are **interconnected** , meaning disruption in one system can trigger cascading impacts across others.
  - They help policymakers and scientists assess whether human activities are pushing Earth beyond its safe operating space.
- **Status of the Nine Planetary Boundaries**
- **Climate Change (Transgressed):** Rising **greenhouse gas** concentrations trap heat, altering global temperatures and climate patterns. Increasing CO_2 levels have pushed this boundary beyond safe limits.
- **Biosphere Integrity (Biodiversity Loss) (Transgressed):** Accelerated species extinction and ecosystem degradation undermine Earth's ecological balance and resilience.
- **Land System Change (Transgressed):** Deforestation, agriculture, and urbanisation have reduced global forest cover below safe levels, weakening **carbon sequestration** and biodiversity.
- **Freshwater Change (Transgressed):** Human disruption of rivers, lakes, and soil moisture cycles threatens water security, ecosystems, and climate regulation.
- **Biogeochemical Flows (Transgressed):** Excess nitrogen and phosphorus from fertilizers disrupt nutrient cycles, causing eutrophication and ecosystem imbalance.
- **Novel Entities (Transgressed):** Plastics, synthetic chemicals, and genetically modified organisms are entering ecosystems without adequate safety assessment.
- **Ocean Acidification (Recently Transgressed):** Oceans have become **30–40% more acidic** since the industrial era, harming corals and shell-forming organisms and weakening carbon absorption.
- **Atmospheric Aerosol Loading (Within Safe Limits (But Risky)):** Airborne particles affect climate and monsoon patterns; currently within limits but regionally disruptive.
- **Stratospheric Ozone Depletion (Within Safe Limits):** Global action under the **Montreal Protocol** **has helped ozone recovery,** making this a success story in environmental governance.

Conclusion

The SOE 2026 report serves as a stark planetary health check, reinforcing the ultimate truth that **"a bad environment can never be good economics."** As India breaches seven of the nine planetary boundaries To achieve the vision of Viksit Bharat @ 2047, India must transition from a model of **"reactive compensation" to one of "proactive restoration."**

Drishti Mains Question:

Q. Discuss the concept of Planetary Boundaries framework as a tool for environmental governance

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are Planetary Boundaries?
Planetary Boundaries define safe ecological limits within which humanity can operate without destabilizing Earth's life-support systems; crossing them risks irreversible environmental change.

2. How many planetary boundaries have been breached as per SOE 2026?
Seven of nine boundaries, including climate change, biodiversity loss, land-system change, freshwater depletion, biogeochemical flows, novel entities, and ocean acidification.

3. Why is ocean acidification a major concern?
Ocean acidity has increased by 30–40% since the industrial era, threatening coral reefs, marine biodiversity, and the ocean's carbon absorption capacity.

4. What is the link between Lantana camara and human–tiger conflict?
The invasive plant suppresses native grasses, reduces prey availability, and forces tigers to prey on livestock, increasing human–tiger encounters.

5. What institutional reforms does the SOE 2026 report recommend?
Strengthening the National Green Tribunal, integrating planetary boundaries into national accounting, and promoting community-led landscape governance.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/Dok3aefGZ_I**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q . Discuss global warming and mention its effects on the global climate. Explain the control measures to bring down the level of greenhouse gases that cause global warming, in the light of the Kyoto Protocol, 1997. (2022)

India-Nepal MoU for Transboundary Conservation

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Source: PIB

The **Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (India)** and the Ministry of Forests and Environment (Nepal) signed an **MoU** to promote bilateral cooperation in **forests** , **wildlife** , **environment** , **biodiversity conservation** , and **climate change** .

- **Landscape-Level Conservation:** The MoU envisages cooperation in formulating biodiversity conservation strategies at the **landscape level** , with emphasis on **key species** including the **elephant** , **Gangetic dolphin** , **rhinoceros** , **snow leopard** , **tiger** , and **vultures** .
- **Focus on Transboundary Ecosystems:** Recognizing their **shared ecosystems** and **transboundary wildlife habitats** , both countries agreed to strengthen **coordination** , with a specific focus on restoring **wildlife corridors** and **interlinking areas** .
  - E.g., **Khata Corridor** (linking Nepal's Bardia National Park with India's Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary).
  - **Valmiki-Chitwan linkage** (**Valmiki Tiger Reserve** in India (Bihar), adjacent to Chitwan National Park and Parsa Wildlife Reserve in Nepal)
- **Combating Wildlife Crime:** A key component of the agreement is addressing **biodiversity conservation threats** and combating **forest and wildlife crime** through strengthened capacity building of frontline staff of enforcement agencies.
  - E.g., curbing poaching for **Rhino horns** , poaching for **tiger skins** , bones, claws, teeth, and other parts, poaching for elephant’s **ivory (tusks),** etc.
- **Commitment to Multilateral Agreements:** Both India and Nepal agreed to cooperate on **multilateral environmental agreements and conventions** as they are parties to the **International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA)** , **Convention on Biological Diversity** (CBD, 1992), **Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora** (CITES, 1973), etc.

Read More: Sagarmatha Sambaad and Preserving Himalayas

Death Anniversary of VD Savarkar

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Source: PIB

The Prime Minister paid tributes to **Vinayak Damodar Savarkar** (Veer Savarkar) on his **60 th**

death anniversary (26 th February, 2026). He passed away in Mumbai on **26 th February, 1966** .

Vinayak Damodar Savarkar

- **About:** He was a revolutionary nationalist, political ideologue, and social reformer, and influenced by leaders like **Bal Gangadhar Tilak** , **Lala Lajpat Rai** , and **Bipin Chandra Pal** . He was also known as **Swatantryaveer Savarkar** .
- **Revolutionary Nationalism:** Founded the **Mitra Mela** in **1899** , which later evolved into the **Abhinav Bharat Society** in **1904** . He also established the **Free India Society** in **London (1906)** . He was closely associated with **India House** (founded by **Shyamji Krishna Varma** in London), a hub for revolutionary activities.
- **Trial and Kala Pani:** He was arrested for conspiring to murder the **Nashik collector (Nasik Conspiracy Case, 1910)** . He famously attempted to **escape** the British while being transported via **Marseilles** (France) but was recaptured.
  - After trial, he was sentenced to **50 years' imprisonment** and deported to the infamous **Cellular Jail (Kala Pani)** in the **Andaman and Nicobar Islands** in **1911** . He was eventually released in **1924** after writing multiple **mercy petitions (1911–1920)** .
- **Political Career:** Served as the **President of the Hindu Mahasabha (1937–1943)** . He opposed the **Quit India Movement (1942)** , calling it impractical. He also engaged in discussions on the **Cripps Mission (1942)** and **Wavell Plan (1945)** .
- **Social Reform:** He fought caste discrimination by promoting **inter-caste marriage** , establishing the **Patit-Pavan Mandir in Ratnagiri** in **1931** for Dalit temple entry, and supporting the **right of sea-crossing** .
- **Literary Contributions:** He authored the influential book **The History of the First War of Indian Independence (1909)** , which redefined the 1857 uprising as a **unified nationalist struggle** , and he sometimes used the **pen-name "Mahratta"** for his writings (e.g., book Essentials of Hindutva).
  - In **1923** , while interned in **Ratnagiri** , he wrote **"Hindutva: Who is a Hindu?"** , defining India as a **Hindu Rashtra** based on **cultural and civilizational identity** .
- **Legacy:** In a symbolic recognition, **Port Blair Airport** was renamed **Veer Savarkar International Airport (2002)** .

Read More: **Veer Savarkar Jayanti**

CERT-In Framework for Space Cyber Security

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Source: PIB

The **Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In)** , in collaboration with SatCom Industry Association (SIA-India), has released a comprehensive **advisory framework for Space Cyber Security** to protect **India's space assets** from evolving **cyber threats** .

- The framework aims to foster a culture of **resilience** , **accountability** , and **proactive risk management** , promoting **"secure-by-design" architectures** in India's expanding space ecosystem.
- The guidelines are **advisory in nature** and apply to **all stakeholders** , including government agencies, satellite service providers, ground station operators, vendors, and private space enterprises.

Key Provisions of the Framework

- **Threat Assessment:** Identifies specific risks to space systems, such as **signal jamming** , **spoofing** , **unauthorized command uplink** , ground station compromise, and firmware manipulation.
- **Segment-wise Security Controls:** Mandates security measures across the space segment, ground infrastructure, communication links, and user terminals, covering **authentication** , **encryption** , **access control** , and **intrusion detection** .
- **Incident Response:** Outlines mandates for **incident detection** , **response** , and **reporting** in alignment with CERT-In Directions.
- **Governance:** Emphasizes the appointment of a **Chief Information Security Officer (CISO)** within organizations operating **SatCom systems** .
- **Supply Chain Security:** Includes provisions for risk assessment, **supply chain security** , and **equipment certification** .
- **Alignment with Global Standards:** The framework aligns with international cybersecurity frameworks, including those from the **International Telecommunication Union (ITU)** , Consultative Committee for Space Data Systems (CCSDS), **National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST)** , **SPACE-Shield** , **TREKS** (Targeting, Reconnaissance, & Exploitation Kill Chain for Space) and SPARTA (Space Attack Research and Tactic Analysis).

CERT-In

- Designated under **Section 70B** of the **Information Technology Act, 2000** , **CERT-In** is **India's national agency** for responding to **cyber threats** like hacking and phishing.
- Operating under the **Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology** since **2004** , it runs a **24×7 help desk** to handle **cyber incidents** and provides prevention and security management

services.

Read More: **Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In)**